



Tony Welk donned his warmest duds and joined several other people in Almonte Sunday and the surrounding area who were forced to shovel, plow and snowblow their way out of their driveways after mother nature dumped around 25 centimetres of snow on Mississippi Mills and the surrounding area during a storm Saturday night. The storm made driving conditions treacherous for those heading out to ring in the New Year.

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Assessments reflect changes in tax rates paid by local property owners

By Phil Ambroziak
Gazette reporter

Over the last little while, when local property owners made that morning trip to their mail boxes, open the ice-caked lid and dispense with the customary junk mail, bills and more junk mail, they were met with something that may have appeared to be somewhat out of the ordinary.

Recently, the Ontario Property Assessment Corporation (OPAC) sent out property assessment notices to all property owners across Ontario. These notices reflect a property's assessed value as of June 30, 1999.

"We have analyzed the real estate market transactions that occurred in 1999 and used an average of statistics to determine the average selling price of similar homes," said Mike Tremblay, assessment commissioner for OPAC. "The notices have been sent to all ratepayers to advise them of the estimated value of their property. We don't do taxes, we're here to ensure that property values are accurate and fair and to make sure

there is an equal distribution of the tax burden.

OPAC, which used to be a part of the ministry of finance, is a corporation that works at arms-length from the provincial government. It is a non-profit organization that is governed by a 14-member board of directors, 12 of which are municipal officials or employees and two being provincial appointees.

"The mandate of OPAC is to evaluate all of the properties in Ontario on a regular reassessment cycle," Tremblay noted.

The corporation's first reassessment took place in 1998 for the 1998 to 2000 taxation period, and was based on the June 30, 1996 value assessment.

"For those three years, property owners were paying rates based on 1996," Tremblay explained.

The second reassessment cycle begins now, with the current notices addressing 2001 to 2002 and reflecting the June 30, 1999 date.

Tremblay said that upon receiving their notices, ratepayers should first read

it over for accuracy, making sure that their names are correct and that the property is categorized properly, whether it is residential, commercial or other.

"After that, the most important thing to look at is the June 30, 1999 value which is located on the right hand side of the document," he said. "If the ratepayer feels that it's a fair estimate he or she can file the notice away."

Tremblay also noted that most owners tend to be familiar with the approximate value of their property and if anyone has concerns over their estimate being either too high or too low they can contact the assessment office for general information at 1-866-296-6722 or for more specific information at 1-800-267-0836.

"People can call and speak to an assessor," Tremblay said. "We have to ensure that the documentation on their property is accurate but if they're still doubtful they can request for comparables to similar properties."

OPAC will provide

property owners with up to six comparables and there is no fee for the service. Afterward, if the ratepayer is still not satisfied, he or she has the right to make an appeal to the Assessment Review Board, an independent tribunal that works at an arms-length from OPAC.

"Before anyone appeals, though, I invite them to contact the assessment office so we can make sure the document is correct," Tremblay said.

The notices were sent out on November 16 to more than 4 million property owners across the province and Tremblay said that the majority of ratepayers should have already received their assessments. The assessments will help determine how much property tax individuals will have to pay, however the amount of these rates is ultimately decided by individual municipality budgets.

"When it comes to paying taxes, it's a personal issue," Tremblay noted.

"If it can be treated fair and equitably, we've done our job."

CDSBEO, teachers approve agreement

By Lianne Lahale
Canadian reporter
KEMPTVILLE

After months of lengthy and frustrating negotiation sessions, members of the Catholic District School Board of Eastern Ontario (CDSBEO) and its teachers are breathing sighs of relief.

The two-year collective agreement, which spans until August 31, 2002, was a result of months of bitter negotiation sessions between the board and its teachers. A final round of negotiations held December 7, 8 and 9 ended the lengthy bargaining battle when both sides were finally able to come up with a tentative agreement.

At a ratification meeting held last Wednesday, board members unanimously passed the agreement while 85 per cent of the approximately 300 teachers in attendance voted in favor of passing the agreement.

Of the several issues teachers laid out before the board for negotiation purposes, the two most important issues of concern were lack of preparation time at both elementary and secondary levels and on calls, which require teachers to act as substitutes in case another teacher is ill or away, at the secondary level.

Teachers originally asked for 200 minutes of preparation time, but the board

maintained that there simply isn't enough money to fund 200 minutes.

As for on-calls, teachers originally asked that they be totally eliminated because of the extra course Bill 74 requires them to teach each semester. The board proposed eliminating on-calls during the semester which requires teachers to teach an extra course, stating that totally eliminating on-calls was impossible because of the board's lack of supply teachers.

The teachers, unhappy with the board's proposals, proceeded to impose sanctions which include no longer participating in staff meetings, writing comments on report cards, taking part in parent/teacher interviews outside of school hours, decorating hallways or bulletin boards, collecting money for fundraising or any other activities and 'pink-listing' the board to prevent the hiring of any new teachers. As a result, the board recently threatened teachers with the possibility of a lock-out, closing the doors to all schools in the board, until matters were resolved.

The new agreement attempted to resolve those issues, along with a few others. Teachers will be receiving a 1 per cent salary increase, retroactive to September 1 of this year, an additional one per cent

increase on January 1, 2001 and another one per cent increase on September 1, 2001. In addition, improvements have also been made in transfer/vacancy posting procedures, which are used when teachers request transfers to other schools. Improvements were also made to the amount of money teachers can claim for vision care and the purchase of eyeglasses every two years.

As for the preparation time dilemma, the agreement settled on a base amount of 160 minutes of preparation time for teachers with compensatory time which will take the form of early dismissal days, release days and professional activity days added on to give teachers the equivalent of the 200 minutes of preparation time they had originally asked for. As for on-calls, the agreement puts a cap on the on-call situation and states that during the semester that teachers are not required to teach an extra course, they will be asked to perform a maximum of 20 on-calls during that semester. During the semester that teachers are required to teach the extra course, they will not be required to perform those supervision duties.

"It feels so good to finally have this over with," said board Chair Nancy Kirby. "I think it's a fair agreement

and now we can finally get back to doing the most important thing of all which is taking care of our children's education and mending the fences of the board's relationship with its teachers."

Eastern Unit of the Ontario English Catholic Teachers' Association (OECTA) President Peter Peckham says although 85 per cent of teachers were in favor of passing the contract, he doesn't think very many teachers are happy with the agreement.

"We came up with the best contract we could given the circumstances," Peckham said. "Despite the high vote of teachers who approved the agreement, not many of them are happy with it. This high vote doesn't reflect that teachers are happy with it, it reflects that the teachers were just tired and frustrated with all this negotiation and they just wanted it over with. I think a lot of them felt that enough was enough."

Peckham says the next step for the board will be to repair the gaps in its relationship with the teachers.

"This round of negotiations definitely left a bitter taste in the mouths of the teachers," Peckham said. "The relationship the board had with its teachers deteriorated since these negotiations and the board is going to have to fix things."

Computer, couch available at the Hub

The Hubcycle is a free service provided by the Hub and the Almonte Gazette. If you need an item or want to give one away, call Kathy at 256-0137.



L-shaped sectional couch and a one piece couch.

Needed:

An exersaucer type of baby holder. Call Diane at 271-0283.

Baby crib needed! Call Les at 253-3076.

To give away:

286 computer - great for word processing! Yours to have. Call Flo at 256-0820.

Washer and dryer in working condition and a La-Z-boy. Call Cathy at 256-8107 or Eva at 9311.

Bingo goes to the vacuum cleaner

The Lanark County Ontario Provincial Police (OPP) have received several phone calls from people living in and around Smiths

Falls recently. The callers have just one question - are the bingo cards they received in the mail legitimate? The short answer is yes.

However, understand this, those bingo cards are a pro-

OPP News

By Const. Neil Fennell



motion intended to aid in the demonstration and sale of vacuum cleaners. In order to receive a gift you must first call the phone number shown on the bingo

card and you will then be offered a home visit and product demonstration.

What we have here is a sales technique. No crime. Let the buyer beware.

Do you want to place an advertisement in The Almonte Gazette or The Herald-Gazette? Call Marjory at 256-1311 and go for it!



The Grade 2-3 class at Pakenham Public School number of 'Hallelu' at the school's Christmas assembly December 20. was perfectly choreographed during their dance

We want to know what you think!
Please send your signed Letters to the Editor and share your opinion about events in the community.

To Have and To Hold...2001



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